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English 393 Technical Communication, Section 10

Rhetorical Analysis

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Behold, A Beagle Billboard



Billboard on Generals Highway in Annapolis, Maryland

What makes for an effective advertisement? This is a question that has been analyzed by many and solved by few, primarily because of the complexity in creating advertisements. There are many choices that must be made during development, a fact that is certainly true for all types of ads. Advertisers must make difficult decisions regarding content, message, location, and other factors. This results in a great variety of end results, with ads ranging from extremely minimalist with a simple message to audacious with vivid colors and imagery. The choices made are influenced by the elements of rhetoric. Rhetoric is essentially the means by which the author of a text wishes to sway or affect their audience. While the existence of a definitive answer to the proposed problem is unlikely, this paper will explore it through a rhetorical analysis of a billboard, discussing the concepts of purpose, style, audience, appeals, and genre.

The billboard in question can be found on Generals Highway in Annapolis Maryland. It is one that I drive past every day I commute to school. While it is outside of the more densely populated areas of Annapolis, it is close to one of the major entrances onto I-97, meaning many hundreds of people see it daily. It advertises a dog boarding and daycare service, mentioning its location, “Just Past Bean Rush Cafe!”, on an arrow, found under a picture of three dogs playing in a field. Further, its name uses red text on a blue background so that it is more eye-catching, with a half-cursive font reading “Happy Tails Pet Resort”. There is also a clipart image of a dog sleeping. The billboard is not particularly tall, probably about 10 to 15 feet high at the most. Overall, the billboard is an effective advertisement of the business. This argument will be supported through further analysis of the aforementioned elements.

A text is typically defined by its purpose, which could be the argument it wants to make, actions it wants to incite, or information it wants to provide. In the case of this billboard, its purpose is to advertise pet services, though it is likely that the true goal of the *Happy Tails*

business is to provide comfortable housing and escapes for dogs. This is apparent because it explicitly mentions the “Daycare” and “Dog Park” next to an image of dogs playing and having fun, which gives the impression that the creators of the billboard care about the happiness of dogs and wishes to help provide it.

The audience is the group of people for which the text was produced, and it is almost entirely dependent upon what the author seeks to achieve with their work. In this case the audience is trivial; local pet owners. More specifically, it is probably intended for pet owners who are busy and do not have a great deal of time to spend with their pets. Thus, the resort will provide entertainment and housing for the dogs. While this may be a relatively small audience, especially in an area which is not the most densely populated, it certainly appeals to these people strongly in that they will want their pets to be as happy as they can possibly be, and the resort provides this while allowing the owners to go about their daily activities. It is also specifically mentioned on the *Happy Tails* website that owners can give their dogs a vacation while they themselves take one.

In terms of rhetoric, style can be described as the specific and unique choices made by the author of a text in order to best achieve its intended purpose. Almost everything in text is the result of a choice, and there are rarely things done by accident. One major choice the creator of the billboard made was to not include an address, website URL, or even a phone number despite its description of the location. This could make it difficult for people to actually find the place, but if the other elements of the ad are sufficiently effective, then it may be inconsequential as they would probably seek this information out. Another pertinent choice is that it uses italics and an arrow for “*Just Past Bean Rush Cafe*” in the bottom right corner. The italics might be to give the billboard more variety in terms of appearance, making it more interesting to look at, whereas

the arrow represents directionality and could be effective in physically drawing the viewer into the resort. The billboard also uses easily legible fonts, making it easier for the reader to comprehend its message. Furthermore, the billboard is particularly tall, which could limit the amount of people who see it, but this is somewhat canceled out by the fact that it is on a fairly busy road on the outskirts of Annapolis. All of these choices were considered before the billboard was finalized, and it is debatable whether alternative options should have been selected. However, it would be difficult to say what specifically should be changed about the billboard, especially considering what it is advertising. That is, any changes made might hinder its effectiveness.

Perhaps the most common and crucial technique in rhetoric is the use of appeals. This billboard mostly appeals to the emotions of those reading it, a concept known as pathos. Many people who see the picture of the dogs playing will feel a sense of happiness, and generally people are more likely to invest in a product or service if they feel it will help bring them more happiness. There is also an underlying sense of pathos which might make viewers feel they *should* give their dogs a nice place to stay when they are not home, which can also make the billboard a more effective advertisement. The billboard also achieves its purpose by having a fun and lighthearted tone, which in turn ties back into its emotional appeal. This tone becomes apparent upon considering the clipart image, which looks like it could be out of a classic newspaper comic. There is certainly a chance that drivers may see the clipart and associate it with a character they like and that they are familiar with, leading them to make a connection with the ad itself, making them more likely to visit the resort and perhaps utilize its services.

Genres are defined as “a category of artistic, musical, or literary composition characterized by a particular style, form, or content” (Merriam-Webster). They come with sets of

rules and conventions that compositions adhere to. In this case, billboards can be described as a genre. As mentioned earlier, billboards can vary significantly in terms of their content, so it is difficult to pinpoint the exact conventions of them. However, it might be argued that the billboard in question adheres to the most basic elements of billboards because it is relatively simplistic in its composition. While many billboards are provocative or minimalist, this one cannot be described as such since it is straightforward in what it is advertising and does not seem interested in making the viewer think deeply, - it is simply interested in telling the reader about the benefits offered by the resort.

The billboard selected for this analysis is an interesting one for a number of reasons, and its effectiveness can certainly be argued in either direction. After analyzing the billboard, it can be concluded that there is no true method which is most effective in achieving its purpose, because there are a multitude of variables that affect the creator's choices. This can be extrapolated to say that an effective billboard in one location with particular stylistic choices may not be as effective in a different location with all other variables remaining unchanged. This is true of any of the variables previously discussed in the analysis. The billboard selected for this paper does have its weaknesses, namely its omission of certain details such as a lack of precise contact information. That said, it is effective because it catches the attention of drivers, has specific appeals to its target audience, and is located in a relatively high-traffic area. In general, virtually every advertisement will have its strengths and weaknesses, so perhaps the answer to the question of effectiveness may not be having the most strengths, but the fewest weaknesses.

References/Works Cited

-Happy Tails Pet Resort website: <https://www.happytailspetresort.com/>

-Genre definition: <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/genre>